kanu's elder brother had been Assam's director general of police until 2023 and then chief information commissioner until November 2025. Another brother is the sitting vice-chancellor of Gauhati University. That proximity became the basis for the case against the CM. Publicly, Sarma didn't blanch, declaring in the assembly that Zubeen had been murdered, contradicting Singapore's ruling. His police, meanwhile, arrested Mahanta and others, deflating the Opposition's prosecutorial energies.

Engineering Advantage

If the man and method explain the politics, the welfare architecture secures the mandate. Between May 2021 and March 2026, Sarma's government ran more than 40 distinct beneficiary schemes, reaching 75 per cent of Assam's population. The centrepiece is Orunodoi, the monthly cash transfer to women, now covering 3.8-4 million households. Launched under Sonowal at Rs 830 a month, it rose under Sarma to Rs 1,000 in 2021, Rs 1,250 in 2022 and Rs 1,500 from January 2026. In February 2026, weeks before the polls, every beneficiary received an advance of Rs 9,000, combining four months of pending payments with a Rs 3,000 Bohag Bihu bonus.

Besides the cash transfers, Sarma delivered visible, fast-paced development. Rural roads lengthened. Bridges and flyovers came up, often before deadlines. A semiconductor unit came to Morigaon. More than 100,000 transparent government jobs were delivered as promised, with another 200,000 pledged for the next term. According to RBI data, Assam's GSDP (Gross State Domestic Product) grew 45 per cent between FY20 and FY25, against the national average of 29 per cent, the fastest expansion of any state in that period. Massive police operations curbed drug trafficking. Rhino poaching, a chronic embarrassment for decades, was ended.

Then, the maps shrunk his grey areas. In 2023, Assam's constituencies were redrawn. Muslim voters once had meaningful influence over roughly 35 seats. That was compressed to 22, giving the BJP 13 more seats to fight for—it ended up gaining 18 overall. The Congress was hit hard. Its 30 per cent vote share, mostly among Muslims, was intact. But its concentration in fewer seats resulted in a drop of 10 seats.

This was tied to his identity plank, where Sarma broke ground in ways no one in his party had in Assam. For the past four decades, the Assamese sub-nationalist tradition—built around opposition to illegal immigrants from Bangladesh—was religion-neutral even though most of these immigrants are Muslims. Where Sonowal spoke of *jati*, *mati* and *bheti* (community, land and home), Sarma fused that grammar with the harder vocabulary of religious self-defence. He made Hindu, Assamese and tribal identity feel like one political category.

The composition of Assam's new Opposition—22 of its 24 MLAs are Muslim—only reinforces Sarma's core argument that the Opposition stands on the other side of the religious divide

The fusion was visible across his tenure. He led aggressive eviction drives against immigrant-origin Muslims, consolidating indigenous opinion. He pushed bans on polygamy and child marriage, which found silent resonance even among Muslim women. He called for indigenous communities to "harass" Miyas, the local term for Muslims of Bangladeshi-immigrant origin. On May 4, the result was a Hindu consolidation Assam had never seen before.

Around this stood the ideological absorption machine. Of the 90 candidates the BJP fielded, at least 30 were imports from the Congress, AGP and smaller regional and tribal formations. The most important defections were not the most arithmetically valuable. Former Congress president Bhupen Bora had last won in 2011. Two-time MP Pradyut Bordoloi had lost his last assembly contest in Margherita in 2016. Sarma recast both as stalwarts, branded them "the last Hindu leaders" of the Congress and blamed their exits not on Gaurav, but on senior Muslim Congress leader Rakibul Hussain. Both won this time, under Sarma.

Rivals Receding

Inside Assam, the mandate leaves Sarma without a serious challenger. Gaurav, a three-term Lok Sabha MP and the poll campaign's most credible alternative, lost. So did Debabrata Saikia, the outgoing leader of the Opposition, and Ripun Bora, former state Congress president. The only visible Opposition leader left in the assembly is Akhil Gogoi of the Raijor Dal. Beyond Akhil personally, his party has no foothold in the indigenous Assamese imagination, from which any future challenge to Sarma could emerge. The composition of Assam's new Opposition—22 of its 24 MLAs are Muslim—only reinforces Sarma's core argument that the Opposition stands on the other side of the religious divide. Of the Congress's 19 seats, 18 were won by Muslims in Muslim-majority constituencies.

Nationally, a larger shift is under way. Alongside Devendra Fadnavis in Maharashtra and Yogi Adityanath in Uttar Pradesh, Sarma has emerged as one of the BJP's most consequential CMs. He has built this profile through strong Hindu consolidation in a state with a significant Muslim population, constant visibility on Hindi media, and rhetoric that often stretches beyond the party's limits, too. His second term will test whether the BJP sees him as a contender in a post-Modi-Shah order. He has five years to make that case. ■